actions of one's existence are linked with those of former or future lives.[16] In this class of literature, as is evident from the *Ashokavadana*, the former and the 'real' lives of the 'greats' within Buddhism are frequently connected in order to milk various morals from the narrative. This is very much in the tradition of Buddhist sacred biographies, where the same sort of incident happens again and again under changed circumstances and different conditions,[17] the repetition serving as the narrative trope that induces the religious feeling of an approaching marvel—a variety of The Chronicle of a Birth Foretold.

The person of the Buddha is, in this tradition, instrumental in every story where glimmerings of future greatness are first revealed.[18] Here, the Buddha is shown as having encountered an earlier avatara of Ashoka in the city of Rajagriha. Ashoka was, when thus encountered, a young boy, Jaya by name, who lived in this city, Rajagriha, which the sage had entered seeking alms. Walking along Rajagriha's main thoroughfare, the Buddha saw two young boys playing in the dirt. One of them, Jaya, on seeing the Buddha, decided to place a handful of dirt in his begging bowl. Typically, in such a story, the act of offering is accompanied by the formulation of a wish or statement of intent about the merit to be gained by the act. Jaya's statement is straightforward enough. By the good merit he might earn, he said, 'I would become king and, after placing the earth under a single umbrella of sovereignty, I would pay homage to the blessed Buddha.' Children usually have more modest aspirations but Jaya was no ordinary child. The Buddha certainly believed so, as also that Jaya had the character and the resolve to achieve what he wanted. As he predicted, 'the desired fruit would be obtained because of his field of merit.' He therefore received the 'proffered dirt', and thus 'the seed of merit that was to ripen into Ashoka's kingship was planted.' Soon thereafter the Buddha predicted to his disciple Ananda that a hundred years after his death 'that boy will become a king named Ashoka in the city of Pataliputra. He will be a